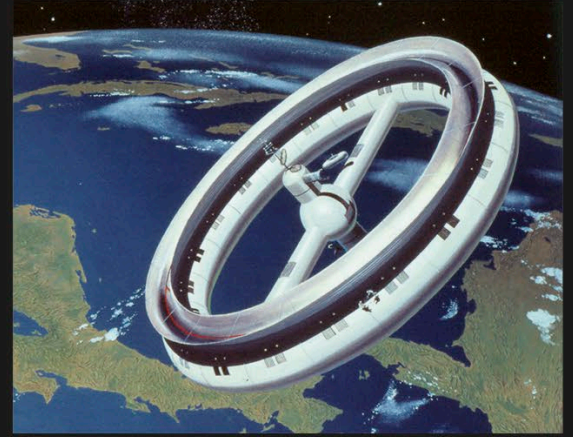


Space stations

Imagine living more than 380 km (235 miles) above everyone else, experiencing a sunrise or sunset every 45 minutes, sending your clothes to be burned up in the atmosphere rather than washed, and having no floor or ceiling. Welcome to life on a space station.



First ideas

Ideas for space stations existed a long time before they became a reality. In the 1950s, the space scientist Wernher von Braun proposed a wheel-shaped design that was 76 m (250 ft) wide.

Space stations

There have been 11 space stations since 1971. They include the following.



Salyut 1 was launched in 1971, and was in orbit for 175 days (of which 24 were occupied).



Salyut 7 was launched in 1982. It was in orbit for 3,216 days (of which 816 were manned).



Skylab, launched in May 1973 by the USA, burned up in 1979.



Mir was built in space by the Soviet Union, beginning in 1986. It fell into the atmosphere in March 2001.

A quick history

The first space station, Salyut 1, was launched in 1971. Since then, a number of stations have orbited the Earth. The International Space Station (ISS), launched in 1998, has been built by 15 nations working together. The largest space station ever built, it's been occupied since 2000. This picture of the ISS was taken in 2005, in mid-build.

